THE CHANGEMAKER

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Heads Jio Studios, the leading homegrown content studio

GUIDING PRINCIPLE
"Back yourself fully...and let your outcomes speak louder than your words. Above all, don't forget to pay it forward and back other women..."

FAVOURITE FILMS
Pulp Fiction* and *Gone with the Wind

WHEN SHE WAS SIX MONTHS OLD, Jyoti Deshpande contracted pneumonia, and then polio on her left leg despite the vaccine. For her journalist father, Krishnan Subbarayan, it was the beginning of a mission to raise a resilient daughter. "He said whatever you can excel in, excel. Replace a negative thought with a constructive positive one," says Jyoti. "Self-esteem and self-image was never an issue for me.... I knew I was differently-abled but I never believed I couldn't do anything."

That meant Jyoti played cricket with boys, competed in lemon-and-spoon races in school and excelled in academics to become the head girl. The same assuredness came in handy as she'd choose to sit for just one placement interview at the S.P. Jain Institute of Management & Research in Mumbai and ace it to land a job at the advertising firm J. Walter Thompson India. Even a move to London, necessitated by marriage, and starting all over again didn't hinder Deshpande's quest to rise. She'd be head of advertising sales for ZEE TV; helped launch B4U Television network; and subsequently worked with Eros International for nearly two decades, producing films like *Devdas*, *Cocktail*, *Bajrangi Bhaijaan* and *English Vinglish*, and getting the company listed in the London and New York stock exchanges and launch Eros Now.

Subbarayan's passing left a deep void and brought Deshpande back home nearly two decades later, and soon she found her new calling. On December 28, 2017, Founder's Day of Reliance Industries Limited, she was seated in front of Mukesh Ambani. "It was a mixed bag of emotions—very humbling, a little scary and lots of excitement," she recalls. "He shared his vision, which was so ahead of its time, in where he saw technology going and how he saw digital transforming the media industry."

Deshpande was entrusted with the job of heading the company's media and entertainment division, which involved board oversight of existing media investments and setting up Jio Studios' content business from scratch.

She's wasted little time to get it going. RIL raised its stake in Viacom18—which during her tenure as CEO acquired the digital rights of the coveted IPL—to 51 per cent, and more recently to over 70 per cent. She also set up and assembled teams for Jio Studios and produced 100-plus web series and features. With Ambani's backing, she is hiring more women, who now occupy 70 per cent of leadership positions at Jio Studios.

Though, her passion lies in storytelling. "I think the war of influence," she says, "is through stories." At Jio Studios, many of these stories are coming from women filmmakers, who are putting sheroes upfront. Says Deshpande, "It's just not about writing a check. I want to tell stories with purpose." ■

–Suhani Singh



Jyoti Deshpande, *53*
President, Media Business, Reliance Industries Ltd

MANDAR DEODHAR